to consumers and the other is a plastic food container. Observe the code shown on it (circled). Do you know what this code means? It is called a '**resin code**'. The resin code represents the type of polymer used to make the plastic.



Figure 15.3 Plastic items used in daily life

(b) Need for resin codes

Plastics should be recycled or disposed of safely. Certain types of plastics should be avoided so that they do not end up polluting the environment or harming our health. Each plastic is composed of a different polymer or set of molecules. Different molecules do not mix when plastics are recycled, it is like trying to recycle paper and glass together. For this reason, they need to be separated. The resin codes of plastics were designed in 1988 and are a uniform way of classifying the different types of plastic which help recyclers in the sorting process.

(c) Find in the resin code on plastic items

The secret resin codes are shown as **three chasing arrows in a triangle**. There is a **number in the middle or letters under the triangle** (an acronym of that plastic type). This is usually difficult to find. It can be found on the label or bottom of a plastic item.

The resin codes are numbered from 1 to 7. Resin codes #1 to #6 each identify a certain type of plastic that is often used in products. Resin code #7 is a category which is used for every other plastic (since 1988) that does not fit into the categories #1 to #6. The resin codes look very similar to the recycling symbol, but this does not mean that all plastics with a code can be recycled.

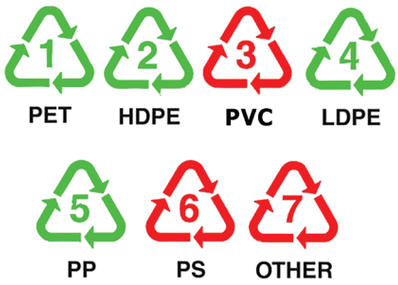


Figure 15.4 Resin codes

(d) Where will the resin code be shown on plastic items?

Flip a plastic item to find the resin code on the bottom.



Sometimes the bottom of plastic item will only have an acronym or the full name of that plastic type.



If you do not find it on the bottom, search for the code on the label.



Some plastics do not have a code. The company did not follow the rules and you do not know if it is safe to use.



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